FIELD STATION

an invented script for

the Method Production Suite

Invented production, invented
people. The suite's shared sample:
Schedule breaks it down, Budget
budgets the schedule.

1 EXT. RIDGE ROAD - DAY 1

Wind comes down off the ridge in long flat gusts, pushing the grass one way and then, for no reason, the other.

A road climbs the ridge in switchbacks. Nobody has driven it since the washout, and the grass is taking it back.

MARA, 40s, walks it with a pack on and four days in her legs. She has the face of someone who fixes things and is never thanked.

DELACROIX, 50s, walks behind her with a paper map folded to the right square. He does not look at it. He looks at the road, and counts.

DELACROIX
Thirty-one.

They take the bend. Gravel lets go under Mara's boot and goes quietly over the edge.

MARA
You don't have to do that out loud.

DELACROIX
The map says forty. I'd like to know when it's lying.

Cloud sits on the ridge above them like a lid somebody forgot to close.

MARA
How long has he been up there?

DELACROIX
Three weeks. On his own.

MARA
They said two.

DELACROIX
They say a lot of things.

The road ends at the washout, a bite taken out of the mountain. Mara stops where the road stops, then goes round it on the rock.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
Thirty-eight.

2 EXT. FIELD STATION - DAY 2

MARA and DELACROIX come up the last of the slope, packs on, bent into the wind. Below them the road they walked is a thin grey line, going all the way down.

The station: a prefab hut bolted to the rock, a radio mast guyed four ways, a fuel drum, a generator crouched under a tarp. Everything that can rattle, rattles.

The hut door opens before they reach it.

TEO, 20s, comes out in two jumpers and no coat. Thin. He has the look of someone who has rehearsed what to say to people and forgotten all of it.

TEO
You came.

DELACROIX
We said we would.

TEO
People say that on the radio. It's different, seeing it.

He shakes Delacroix's hand, then Mara's, then Delacroix's again.

MARA
You're Teo.

TEO
I'm Teo. Sorry. Come in, it's warmer. It isn't, but it's out of the wind.

The wind leans on all three of them. The mast answers it with a low note, like someone humming through their teeth.

TEO (CONT'D)
That's the mast. You get used to it.

MARA
Do you?

TEO
No.

Teo walks them round the station at a pace that makes it hard to see any of it.

TEO (CONT'D)
Fuel. Water. Rain gauge. It's been fine the whole time.

He points up at the mast without looking at it.

TEO (CONT'D)
It sings in a north wind. One long note. In a west wind it's two, and they don't agree.

DELACROIX
And an east wind?

TEO
We don't get an east wind.

He thinks about it.

TEO (CONT'D)
We got one once.

Mara crouches by the generator and lifts the tarp. Oil on the housing, old and new. One bolt is missing. Another turns in her fingers with no thread left to hold it.

She looks at it for a long moment. Then she lets the tarp fall.

DELACROIX
Well?

MARA
It runs.

That is all she says. Delacroix has worked with her long enough to count what she leaves out.

TEO
I kept it running. Every day. I wrote it down.

MARA
I believe you.

Teo nods too many times and goes inside. The wind shuts the door behind him, hard.

3 INT. FIELD STATION - DAY 3

One room. A cot, a table, one chair. A tarp lashed over a gap in the north wall where a panel used to be. It breathes with the weather.

On the wall above the radio, a map of the valley. Four pins in it, running down the line to the lowest station.

DELACROIX
(into the handset)
Base, this is Field Station. We're up.

Static. Then a voice, patient, a long way off.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
Field Station, Iversen. Good to hear you. How's the boy?

Delacroix glances at Teo, who is shelving their tins in order of size.

DELACROIX
Tidy.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
Pickup is tomorrow, first light. Relief team brings the new keeper up and the three of you down.

DELACROIX
First light.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
Weather permitting. It always permits, until it doesn't.

He sets the handset down. Mara is looking at the map.

MARA
Why four pins?

TEO
One for every station on the line. We're the top one.

He touches the lowest pin, then takes his finger away as if it were warm.

4 EXT. RADIO MAST - DUSK 4

The light goes early up here. What is left of it is the colour of weak tea.

MARA climbs the mast, harness clipped to the ladder, a spanner through her belt. The wind pulls at her like it wants her for something.

DELACROIX stands at the foot, the safety line paid out through his gloves.

DELACROIX
How many rungs?

MARA
I don't count them.

DELACROIX
Forty-four. I counted for you.

She reaches the antenna. It hangs off true, its bracket worked loose by a winter of north wind.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
Can I ask you something?

MARA
You're going to.

DELACROIX
Why did you take this job? You could fix things anywhere. Somewhere with walls.

A gust takes the mast and leans it an inch. She waits it out, cheek against the cold steel, eyes shut.

Below her, the line goes taut in his hands and stays taut until the gust is gone.

MARA
Nothing up here pretends to work.

Delacroix thinks about that. Decides not to agree with it out loud.

She sets the spanner to the bracket. Two turns. The antenna comes true, and the mast's low note changes pitch, very slightly, as if it has noticed.

DELACROIX
Is that it?

MARA
That's it.

She doesn't come down. She is looking past him, past the hut, out across the valley to the far ridge.

A light. One small steady point of it, low on the far slope, where the map shows nothing at all.

It does not flicker. Nothing out there has any reason to be lit.

DELACROIX
Mara? You're losing the light.

The point goes out, like somebody closing a hand around it.

MARA
Coming down.

She unclips and starts down, rung by rung. She does not mention it. She will not mention it for some time.

5 INT. FIELD STATION - EVENING 5

Three of them round a table built for one. Tins on a camping stove. The tarp on the north wall breathes in, out.

TEO eats fast, like the food might be taken back.

DELACROIX
Four pins. Tell me about them.

TEO
We call down the line at six every evening. Everybody answers. We all say goodnight.

MARA
Everybody?

Teo puts his fork down.

TEO
The fourth hasn't answered. Nine days.

A pause. The stove ticks as it cools.

DELACROIX
Nine days, and you didn't report it.

TEO
I did. Every night, after I called them, I reported it to base.

DELACROIX
And?

TEO
Nobody answered that either.

Delacroix looks at Mara. Mara looks at the radio. The radio hisses and says nothing, the way it has said nothing for nine days.

MARA
Iversen answered today.

TEO
Iversen answered you.

6 EXT. RIDGE - NIGHT 6

Wind, and under the wind a cold that means business.

DELACROIX walks the ridge with a torch, the beam no use against anything further off than his own boots.

He finds the marker cairn where the map says it will be: a chest-high stack of flat stones, sighted down the valley toward the fourth station. In clear weather you could see its lamp from here.

There is no lamp tonight. There is no clear weather.

He sets the torch on the ground and looks at the cairn properly.

It has been rebuilt. Carefully. Every stone seated, every gap chinked with smaller stones. Nobody did this in a hurry, and nobody did it for the weather.

DELACROIX
Hello?

The wind takes the word and does not bring it back.

He knows this cairn. He built the last one himself, eleven years ago, and he knows how many stones went into it. Twenty-six.

He counts them. His lips move.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
Twenty-five.

He counts again, slower, touching each one with a gloved finger, top to bottom.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
Twenty-five.

One short. Whoever rebuilt it built it well and built it one stone short, and a careful person does not make that mistake by accident.

He sweeps the torch around his feet. Grass. Rock. No stone lying loose.

Down in the valley, where the fourth station should be, there is only dark.

He switches the torch off and stands in it for a moment, to see what his eyes will do.

Nothing out there changes. Nothing out there has changed for nine days.

He turns the torch back on and walks back toward the hut, faster than he came.

7 INT. FIELD STATION - LATER 7

Mara is asleep on the cot in her boots. Teo is not asleep, and not pretending to be.

The radio crackles. Delacroix comes in with the cold still on him and goes straight to the handset.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
Field Station, Iversen. Field Station, do you read?

DELACROIX
Go ahead.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
Weather's closing over the pass. Relief is delayed.

DELACROIX
Delayed how long?

Static, for long enough that Teo sits up.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
Twenty-three hours, earliest. We'll hold here until it...

The hiss closes over the rest.

DELACROIX
Iversen. Come back.

Nothing. Delacroix sets the handset down gently, as if it might still be listening.

He takes a pencil from his pocket and writes 23 on the wall beside the map, small and neat. He looks at it. Underlines it.

TEO
Was that him? Was that really him?

DELACROIX
Go to sleep, Teo.

8 EXT. FIELD STATION - NIGHT 8

The wind has found a new direction and does not like that one either.

TEO wheels the quad bike out of the lean-to. Headlamp on. A jerrycan strapped across the back, and a second map, the survey copy, rolled under his arm.

MARA comes out after him, pulling on her coat.

MARA
Teo.

TEO
It's four hours down if the track's clear. I'll see them. I'll come back and tell you.

MARA
Don't.

TEO
Nine days. Somebody has to go and look.

MARA
In the morning. With us.

TEO
In the morning there'll be a reason to wait until the afternoon.

He is not wrong, and she knows it, and that is the worst part.

MARA
Call us when you get there.

TEO
I always call.

He kicks the bike over. It catches first time, which feels like a verdict.

DELACROIX is in the doorway now, the lamp behind him.

DELACROIX
Four hours down. Four back. The relief is twenty-three.

TEO
Then I'll be back before them.

Teo pulls out onto the track. The headlamp swings across the rock, across the fuel drum, and settles on the way down.

They watch the tail light go. Red, small, smaller. It dips below the lip of the ridge, comes up once more on the next switchback, and then does not come up again.

Mara keeps looking at the place where it was.

DELACROIX
You could have stopped him.

MARA
I could have slowed him down.

Behind them, under its tarp, the generator coughs.

Once. A dry, small sound, like someone clearing their throat before bad news. Then it runs on, even and ordinary, as if nothing happened.

Neither of them says anything. Delacroix looks at his watch and does not say the time.

CUT TO:

9 EXT. LOWER STATION - NIGHT 9

A hut like theirs, lower and older, in a fold of the valley where the wind cannot quite reach and so sulks instead.

A headlamp comes down the track and stops. TEO kills the engine. The silence is enormous.

The door of the hut is open. Not blown open. Propped, with a stone.

TEO
Hello? It's Teo. From the top.

Nothing. He goes in.

Inside, the station is neat. The cot is made. A mug stands on the table with a skin on its cold tea.

The radio is on. Its dial glows a soft green, the only light in the room.

Teo leans in to read the frequency. He knows the number. It is theirs.

Beside the radio a notebook lies open. Line after line of the same entry, in a hand that gets smaller down the page. Six o'clock. Six o'clock. Six o'clock.

Someone has been listening. Every night. And never once said a word.

Teo picks up the handset. His thumb finds the key.

He holds it down.

10 INT. FIELD STATION - NIGHT 10

The generator coughs once and dies. MARA works by the light of her phone, hands steady, and does not look up.

MARA
Give it a minute. It always comes back.

DELACROIX
And if it doesn't?

She finds the housing bolt by feel. Turns it a quarter turn.

MARA
Then we do this in the dark.

The wind takes the tarp on the north wall and holds it open like a door nobody opened.

DELACROIX
That's not an answer.

MARA
It's the one I have.

He crosses to the window. Outside, the ridge is a black line against a slightly less black sky.

DELACROIX
Nineteen hours until the relief team. I counted.

MARA
Then stop counting.

The generator catches. Dies again. Catches.

Light comes up amber and unsteady, and the room assembles itself around them: the cot, the radio, the map with its four pins.

MARA (CONT'D)
There. Told you.

DELACROIX
You told me a minute. That was six.

MARA
I rounded.

She wipes her hands on her thigh and sits, finally, like the sitting costs her something.

DELACROIX
You should sleep.

MARA
You should stop saying that.

A long moment. The radio hisses, says nothing, hisses.

DELACROIX
If the relief doesn't come.

MARA
They'll come.

DELACROIX
If.

MARA
Then we walk out the way we walked in, and it takes four days instead of one, and you complain the entire time.

DELACROIX
I don't complain.

MARA
You're complaining now.

He almost laughs. It is the first honest sound either of them has made all night.

DELACROIX
Get some sleep. I'll take the radio.

She doesn't argue, which frightens him more than the dark did.

CUT TO:

11 INT. FIELD STATION - DAWN 11

Grey light. The tarp is down. The map is gone from the wall.

DELACROIX sits exactly where he sat, the handset still in his fist, asleep with his eyes open the way soldiers learn.

The radio speaks. One word, clipped, in a voice neither of them has heard.

He is awake before he knows he is awake.

DELACROIX
Say again.

Nothing. The hiss closes over the word like water.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
Say again.

He turns the dial one notch, then back, then one notch the other way, hunting the frequency the way you hunt a name you have almost remembered.

MARA (O.S.)
What was it?

She is in the doorway. She has not slept and does not pretend otherwise.

DELACROIX
A voice. One word. I couldn't hold it.

MARA
Which word?

He looks at the handset, then at her.

DELACROIX
Ours.

Outside, very far off, something that is not the wind moves along the ridge.

12 EXT. FIELD STATION - DAY 12

Frost on everything that held still overnight. The fuel drum wears it. The mast does not.

MARA crouches at the mouth of the lean-to. Two lines in the white, a tyre's width apart, run out of it and over the lip of the ridge. Nothing has come back over them.

DELACROIX comes out with two mugs and gives her one. She holds it for the heat.

DELACROIX
Anything?

MARA
He went down. He didn't come up. Frost came at about two. Anything coming back after that would have broken it.

She stands. Her knees have an opinion about it.

MARA (CONT'D)
Nothing broke it.

Delacroix looks at his watch. Eleven times since dawn. He knows it was eleven.

DELACROIX
Four hours down. Four back. He'd have been here by six. It's ten past nine.

MARA
So he stayed. Or he's asleep in a warm hut with his boots off. Which is the one you're not saying.

DELACROIX
I'm saying it now. And the relief is thirteen hours. If they keep to it.

MARA
They won't.

She tips her tea out on the frost. It steams, and then it doesn't.

13 INT. BASE - RADIO ROOM - DAY 13

A long low room at the bottom of the valley, where weather happens to other people. A wall map, the four stations in red tape. A chalked weather board: PASS, RIDGE, LAKE. A radio set the size of a wardrobe, hissing. BASE STAFF come and go with mugs. Nobody hurries.

IVERSEN at the set, 60s, older than his voice. A cardigan buttoned one button wrong. Beside him the DISPATCHER, 30s, sleeves pushed up, her big ruled log open.

IVERSEN
(into the handset)
Pass relay, base. Give me a carrier.

A tone, thin, like a kettle in somebody else's house. Three seconds. Gone.

DISPATCHER
Four times since seven.

IVERSEN
It's the cold. It's only lately it minds.

She writes: RELAY. CARRIER 3 SEC. DROPPED.

Iversen turns back through the green book the night staff keep, looking for the boy's last report. He stops. Nine nights, nine hands, the same words.

FOURTH STATION NO ANSWER AT ROLL CALL. NOTED.

DISPATCHER
Who passed it on?

IVERSEN
Nobody. It says noted.

He runs a finger down the initials. The seventh night's are his own. He looks at them like a photograph of himself he doesn't remember being taken.

IVERSEN (CONT'D)
I remember a boy reading out a list. I thought he was being thorough.

He closes the book and lays his hand flat on it.

IVERSEN (CONT'D)
Write it in yours. Fourth station, no contact, nine days. Reported nightly by the top station. Not acted on.

DISPATCHER
By who?

IVERSEN
By base.

She writes it, and does not soften it. He nods once.

14 INT. FIELD STATION - LAB - DAY 14

A lean-to off the hut, its roof sheet ticking in the sun. A bench, spare parts in labelled tins, logbooks numbered in white paint.

MARA takes down the newest and sits on the only stool.

Teo's hand: upright, schoolroom. One page a day, ruled into six boxes.

DAY 1. WIND N, ONE NOTE. GEN 6 HRS. RAIN 2 MM. CALLED THE LINE. 4 ANSWERED. REPORTED TO BASE.

Nothing missing, nothing crossed out. A ruler every day for three weeks, for nobody.

Day 13: CALLED THE LINE. 3 ANSWERED. She slows. Day 17, squeezed under the box: REPORTED TO BASE AGAIN. She counts to the end with her thumb. Nine.

Day 21 is yesterday. GEN COUGHED ONCE. VISITORS: 2. CALLED THE LINE. 3 ANSWERED.

She reads VISITORS: 2 twice. Something in her face almost goes, and doesn't.

On the shelf, a wooden case lined in green felt, six hollows, five valves. The sixth hollow's felt has not faded. Not empty long. In the lid, an inventory card with Teo's ticks, and older brown ink: SEVEN-PIN. NEW PATTERN SETS ONLY.

Pinned above the bench: LINE SETS. TOP AND TWO, NEW PATTERN. THREE AND FOUR, OLD PATTERN.

She looks from the card to the sheet, and closes the lid very gently.

15 EXT. RADIO MAST - DAY 15

Clear, for once. The valley lies open below like a hand.

MARA near the top, a compass on a lanyard. DELACROIX at the foot, the line through his gloves.

MARA
Where's the lower station from here?

DELACROIX
One six two degrees. Eleven kilometres, give or take the hill in the way.

MARA
This is aimed at base. Nobody's had a reason to move it in thirty years.

DELACROIX
Base is the one that answers.

MARA
Base is the one that isn't.

She walks the antenna round against the wind. The mast's note slides down, unhappily. The line goes taut; he takes the weight without being asked.

DELACROIX
Do you want to know how far up you are?

MARA
No.

He doesn't say it. His lips move anyway.

One six two. She sets the bolts. The note settles lower, with something under it that wasn't there yesterday.

MARA (CONT'D)
If he's at Four. If their set's on. If it's on our frequency.

DELACROIX
That's a lot of ifs.

MARA
It's three. You were counting.

She comes down. He lets her reach the ground without a number.

16 INT. FIELD STATION - DAY 16

The hiss has a new floor under it, like a road a long way off. DELACROIX at the set. MARA behind him, still in her harness.

DELACROIX
(into the handset)
Four, this is the top. Do you read.

A click, and inside it one word, cut at both ends as if with scissors.

TEO (V.O.)
Ours.

DELACROIX
That's the word. From this morning.
(keys)
Say again, over.

He watches his second hand.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
(under his breath)
Fifty-eight. Fifty-nine.

CLOSE ON THE RADIO.

The signal needle lifts off its pin. Trembles.

TEO (V.O.)
Teo.

The needle drops. The hiss.

DELACROIX
It wasn't somebody on our frequency this morning. It was him, at Four. Telling us their set's tuned to ours.

MARA
One word, then a minute. A valve that won't stay seated. It touches long enough for a word, lets go, and has to warm again.

DELACROIX
Can he fix it?

MARA
There's a seven-pin valve gone from the lab. Theirs is the old pattern.

DELACROIX
Meaning.

MARA
Meaning no.

DELACROIX
(keys)
Teo, it's Delacroix. We hear you. Is Ansel with you?

He counts two minutes under his breath and stops at a hundred and twenty, because nothing happens at a hundred and twenty.

He writes on the wall under the 23: 11.40. TEO AT FOUR. He doesn't underline this one.

17 INT. LOWER STATION - DAY 17

Daylight makes the lower station smaller. The cot, made. The mug, its tea gone leathery.

TEO on an upturned crate at the set. He has not slept. On the table, a row of pencil marks, one for every try since dawn.

At sixty on the station clock, he keys.

TEO
Ours. It's Teo, I'm at Four, there's nobody here, the set's...

The red lamp on the panel lit on the first word and has already gone out. A dead key has a softer click; he knows it by now.

He adds a pencil mark. Waits for sixty.

TEO (CONT'D)
Teo.

The lamp lights on the word and dies on the end of it.

He takes a coin to the back panel. Inside, a row of warm valves. One leans in its socket like a loose tooth. He pushes it upright; it leans again. Its spring clip is cracked through.

From his coat he unwraps a twist of cloth: the lab's valve. Seven pins. Theirs has nine.

TEO (CONT'D)
You were never going to fit.

He pockets it. The set needs pliers, a clip, solder and Mara. He has a coin. He screws the panel back on, because leaving it off would be untidy.

The notebook lies square to the table edge. Six o'clock, six o'clock, the hand shrinking. On the last written page, pressed hard enough to dent the paper, an arrow running off the edge, and two letters.

A.V.

Teo follows the line of the arrow across the table. It points at the door.

18 EXT. LOWER STATION - DAY 18

Birches, a stream out of sight, a rain gauge nobody has emptied.

TEO sits on the doorstep and picks up what props the door: a flat grey stone the size of a book. On its face, half rubbed away by nine nights of damp, a chalk arrow. As it lay, it pointed down the valley, toward a lake you can't see from here.

Everyone learns the sign their first week, from a card at base between the knots and the first aid. He has never seen one used.

TEO
Gone this way.

It is not a valley stone. Those are round, washed smooth. This one is split flat and blue-grey, a ridge stone. He doesn't know what that means. Delacroix would. It goes in his pack anyway: somebody left it for somebody, and he is somebody.

Without it the door swings to and latches.

Round the back, the diesel drum is empty; it answers his knuckle like a bell. One jerrycan marked PETROL, half full or less. He fills the quad slowly, not wasting a drop.

Through the window we see him bend over the notebook and write one line under the arrow. Then he rides off down the valley, the way the arrow said.

19 EXT. FIELD STATION - DAY 19

Midday. The wind has come round west; the mast sings two notes that don't agree.

DELACROIX on the bench, lacing his boots like a man deciding something. MARA in the doorway, arms folded.

DELACROIX
The relief gets as far as the washout. Somebody meets them there and takes them on to Four by the old supply path.

MARA
And somebody stays with the set.

DELACROIX
You're faster than me. You go down, I sit by the radio. Nobody can count a minute like I can.

MARA
You know the road and the relief listen to you. You go. If the set breaks I can fix it, and if he keys again I'll know what's wrong by the sound.

They stop at the same moment. The mast fills in, not agreeing.

DELACROIX
One at a time. You first.

Mara doesn't answer. She goes into the hut. He counts without meaning to. Twelve. Thirteen.

She comes out with his pack and sets it at his feet. Packed. Bivvy bag, water, two tins with the opener taped to one, the map folded to the right square, the spare torch with its batteries turned round so they won't drain, which is a thing he does, and she has noticed.

She is not going to say another word.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
While I was talking.

He puts it on. She has done the straps to his length.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
If he keys again.

MARA
I'll write it on your wall. Under the twenty-three.

At the lip of the ridge he lifts a hand. She lifts one back. Then she goes in and sits in his chair, still warm, and puts on the headphones.

20 EXT. RIDGE ROAD - DAY 20

DELACROIX coming down alone. Going down this road, the gravel wants to go with you.

DELACROIX
Thirty-eight.

The washout. He stops to think, where Mara didn't. Then he goes round, one hand on the rock, not looking down, the only way he has ever found to do it.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
Thirty-seven.

The turning circle. An oil stain, a marker post with its paint gone. The end of the road for anything with wheels.

Down the switchbacks, as far as the cloud allows: no vehicle, no sound of one. A raven, going somewhere else.

He sits on the marker post. It was not made to be sat on.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
Thirteen hours.
(checks his watch)
Nine.

He settles in to wait the way he waits for everything: upright, patient, keeping count.

21 EXT. FIRE ROAD - DAY 21

The far side of the range, the dry side. A gravel fire road cut in long pale loops through dark heather.

On it, very small, the quad. A thread of dust stands up behind it and leans away on the wind.

Far below, through a gap in the hills, the lake: a grey coin with nothing on it.

The quad takes a long bend and the hill hides it. The dust hangs on, then the wind takes that too.

22 INT. BASE - RADIO ROOM - DAY 22

Afternoon light in slabs on the floor. On the weather board, PASS reads CLOSED.

The DISPATCHER on the telephone, writing as she talks. IVERSEN at the set behind her, listening with half of himself.

DISPATCHER
(into the phone)
The fourth station. Nine days, no contact.
(listens)
Yes, nine. I know. I've written it down.

Iversen's shoulders heard that.

DISPATCHER (CONT'D)
The pass is shut and the washout's gone. It'll have to be your side, the fire road.
(listens)
Solli. Good. Tell Solli to look for a quad, and a young man who'll tell her everything twice.

She writes: RANGER STATION. FIRE ROAD AT FIRST LIGHT. SOLLI.

DISPATCHER (CONT'D)
First light. I asked for sooner.

IVERSEN
I know you did.
(keys)
Pass relay, base. Give me a carrier.

The tone comes up, clean, holding. For a second his face is a much younger man's.

IVERSEN (CONT'D)
Field Station, Iversen, through the relay. Do you...

A crackle like a match struck. The tone goes, and the hiss that comes back is deader than before.

DISPATCHER
That's eleven.

IVERSEN
Write it down.

23 INT. FIELD STATION - LAB - DUSK 23

The last light lies along the bench like a ruler.

MARA has the spare transmitter open: old pattern, brown enamel, stencilled FOR PARTS. Its insides lie on a cloth in the order they came out. A jeweller's loupe in one eye.

She lifts out a nine-pin valve, checks each pin against the lamp, and sets it apart like a guest of honour. Then its socket. The clip is whole, and rusted solid.

MARA
No. You're no good either. So the valve's fine. It's the seat. It leans, it drops out. It wants something to hold it that isn't a clip. Something thin. Something that springs. You've got tins. You've got...

She hears herself. The voice in the room is hers, and it has been going for a while.

She stops. The roof sheet ticks as it cools.

She picks up an empty tobacco tin with a hinged lid and turns it under the lamp, looking at how thin the metal is.

24 EXT. FIRE ROAD - DUSK 24

Amber light. The lake nearer now, a sheet of pewter in a bowl of hills.

TEO on the quad, on a long straight. The engine coughs: once, dry and small, exactly the sound the generator made the night he left.

It runs on fifty yards. Then it coughs twice and stops, and the quad rolls on in silence until the gravel slows it.

TEO
No.

The starter catches nothing. He kneels by the tank. The petrol smell is too strong. Under the fuel line his hand comes away wet; a drip forms on the union, falls, forms again.

Back up the road, a thin dark line on the gravel, all the way round the bend.

TEO (CONT'D)
You could have said.

He pushes the quad onto the verge, where a truck could pass, and leaves the key in.

His headlamp swings across the roadside rock and stops. At the height of a man's hand, a chalk arrow, pointing on down the road.

He puts his finger near it, not on it.

TEO (CONT'D)
Hello.

The last of the light goes off the lake.

25 EXT. RIDGE - DUSK 25

A knuckle of rock on a side spur above the washout. The far slope lies open: Mara's view from the mast, two nights ago, at this hour.

DELACROIX comes up onto it breathing hard. He is here because of something he saw that night, which was not a light. It was Mara's face at the top of the mast, looking past him at the far slope, very still. Then not mentioning it. He counts what she leaves out.

He finds her line on the map and sights his pencil along it: a low shoulder where the map shows nothing at all.

The light goes from green to grey to black. Nothing on the shoulder. Not a flicker. He waits a while longer, because being sure is not the same as knowing.

DELACROIX
So somebody lit it. And it isn't there tonight.

He puts a small pencil cross on the shoulder.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
You moved.

It frightens him a little, how much better that is than the alternative.

26 INT. FIELD STATION - BUNKHOUSE - NIGHT 26

A second small hut, unheated, unused this season. Cold blankets and mice.

MARA comes in with a torch. Four bunks. A shelf of grey blankets, each with a stencilled number. She takes two, then a third, because the night will be colder than this.

The beam goes up the wall above the bunks, and stops.

Names, carved into the boards, crowding each other. Initials, dates, a bad drawing of the mast, singing. Relief teams, year after year, on the one wall nobody would paint.

ANSEL, in block capitals, a date that makes him a young man. Further along, shallower: ANSEL, fifteen years later. And low on a bottom-bunk post, nearly at the floor, as if done lying down: ANSEL. No date. The wood in the letters is still pale.

Pinned above it, a photograph: four keepers in this yard on a summer day, a kettle on the step, the mast behind them straight. All four smiling. Nobody up here smiles like that now. On the back, in pencil: HANDOVER. ALL FOUR.

The man on the left is Ansel. She knows it before she knows how: the same block capitals in the way he stands.

She pins it back through the same hole and goes out. The beam leaves the names one by one, and they go back to being a wall.

27 EXT. FIELD STATION - NIGHT 27

Six o'clock, full dark, the generator off to save fuel.

MARA on the footing of the mast by the field jack, a weatherproof box bolted to its leg. The handheld plugged in. Teo's logbook on her knee, a clean page ruled by headlamp into six boxes.

MARA
Roll call. This is the top station calling the line. Two, this is the top.

A voice comes back, small, far off and cheerful about it: a man she has never met, answering his station's name. The words are lost. The shape of them is right.

MARA (CONT'D)
Thank you, Two. Three, this is the top.

She gives it a full minute, because Delacroix would. Nothing.

MARA (CONT'D)
Four, this is the top.

She waits, knowing.

MARA (CONT'D)
Top station. Here. Goodnight, all.

She writes in Teo's boxes, as near to his hand as she can make her own.

DAY 22. WIND W, TWO NOTES. GEN COUGHED TWICE. VISITORS: 1. CALLED THE LINE. 2 ANSWERED. REPORTED TO BASE.

She hasn't, yet. She keys.

MARA (CONT'D)
Base, top station. Two answered. Three no answer tonight. Four no answer, ten days.

Hiss. It is true now, so she leaves it written.

28 EXT. FIRE ROAD - NIGHT 28

Dark the way it is only dark a long way from anything.

TEO walks the middle of the road in the cone of his headlamp. The stone in his pack knocks his spine at every step.

A bend. On a boulder, a chalk arrow.

TEO
There you are.

The next bend. An arrow, lower down the rock.

TEO (CONT'D)
And you. You're getting lower. Did you notice?

He holds his hand at his shoulder. Then at his knee. He doesn't like what that means, so he talks about something else.

TEO (CONT'D)
I didn't call the line tonight. First time in twenty-one days. Twenty-two. Mara will have done it. In my boxes.

The next arrow is at the foot of a marker post, so low he nearly misses it. Beside it on the gravel, a smear, as if something heavy had been dragged.

TEO (CONT'D)
That's all right. I've got it.

He waits, the way you wait on the radio after you have said your piece. Nothing answers.

He finds he doesn't mind. The arrows say the same thing every time: this way. It is the most anyone has said to him in nine days.

29 INT. BASE - RADIO ROOM - NIGHT 29

Half the strip lights off. A sandwich at Iversen's elbow, its corners curling. The DISPATCHER's coat on her chair; she was meant to go home at four. The wall clock says two minutes past six.

The relay tone comes up under the hiss, clean, holding. IVERSEN sits up.

Faint, in pieces: a woman's voice calling the line. A station number. A wait the length of a minute. Top station. Here. Goodnight, all.

DISPATCHER
That isn't the boy.

IVERSEN
That's the engineer. She's doing his roll call. In his order.

Her voice again, flatter: two answered, three no answer, four no answer, ten days. A crackle. The tone goes.

DISPATCHER
Ninety seconds. About.

IVERSEN
Write it down. And write down that the top station is still calling. Write down who's calling. Write down who isn't.

DISPATCHER
Three didn't answer tonight.

IVERSEN
Then write that.

Her pen is loud in the half-lit room. He keys into the dead hiss, knowing nobody can hear.

IVERSEN (CONT'D)
Field Station, Iversen. Roll call received.

30 EXT. RIDGE ROAD - NIGHT 30

The turning circle at the washout. Cold up off the gravel and down off the sky at once.

DELACROIX in a bivvy bag against the marker post. No relief. No headlights on the switchbacks, which he could see all the way down now the cloud has lifted.

He looks at his watch, and makes himself put it away. Above him, more stars than anyone needs.

DELACROIX
One. Two. Three.

He reads across the sky like a page. He loses his place over the ridge line and goes back to the last one he was sure of.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
Forty-one.

It is no good. Every star is a minute, every ten a bend of the road. The hours add themselves up underneath whether he counts them or not.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
Ninety-nine. A hundred.

There are plainly a great many more. He gives up on them with something like respect, buttons his watch into the top pocket of the pack, and lies back under the sky, uncounted.

31 INT. FIELD STATION - NIGHT 31

One candle in a jar. The map back on the wall, four pins catching the light. Beside it, under the 23 and the 11.40. TEO AT FOUR, a new line in a squarer hand: 18.00. ROLL CALL. 2.

The tarp on the north wall breathes in. Out.

MARA in the chair at the radio, three numbered blankets round her, the handset on her knee, its cord looped once round her wrist so it can't fall.

The radio hisses. She listens to it the way you listen to someone breathing in the next room.

Her eyes close. She opens them. Outside, the mast holds one long note, and then two.

Her eyes close, and stay closed. Her thumb rests beside the key, not on it. It is the first time she has slept since they came up the road.

The candle burns down a finger's width. Nothing on the radio all night. It doesn't stop listening, and neither, quite, does she.

32 EXT. KETTLE LAKE - DAWN 32

The lake lies in the bottom of the valley like something set down and forgotten. Flat, grey, no wind on it at all. After three days of wind the stillness feels like a held breath.

TEO comes out of the trees on the last of the arrows, headlamp still on, wet to the shin. His pack sits low on one shoulder, heavier than it should be.

Across a bay, a timber boathouse stands on legs over the water. Smoke from its stove pipe goes straight up, the way smoke never does at the station.

TEO
Hello. Over there.

The sound goes out across the water and does not come back. The lake takes it the way the ridge took Delacroix's, only more politely.

He swings the pack round and checks something inside without taking it out. A flat stone, chalk on one face. He buckles the pack again, both buckles.

TEO (CONT'D)
(to himself)
Round, then.

He walks the shore: shingle, reeds, a fallen tree he climbs over, and climbs back over, because the far side of it is deeper.

33 EXT. BOATHOUSE - DAWN 33

Planks gone silver, a jetty, a rowboat alongside. A white skiff keel-up on trestles. Nets on a line, stiff with cold.

The door opens. AUD, 70s, steps onto the jetty with an oar held across her body. Not like a paddle. Like the other thing.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
That's far enough.

TEO
I'm Teo. From the top station. Cold Spring.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
Never heard of you.

TEO
You might have. On the radio. At six.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
Say it, then. What you say at six.

TEO
Cold Spring calling the line. Cold Spring calling the line. Goodnight, all stations.

The oar comes down an inch.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
You say it too fast. And you say goodnight before anybody's answered.

TEO
That's so I don't forget.

The oar comes down the rest of the way. She leans it by the door, within reach.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
Aud. You walked.

TEO
The bike gave up. Then I followed the arrows. Chalk, one on every bend.

Something moves in her face. She does not let it get far.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
Someone came this way. A week ago.
(beat)
Crawling, mostly.

TEO
Is he alive.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
Tea first. You're blue. Then you can see for yourself, and I don't have to say it.

She goes in and leaves the oar where it is. He notices that, and follows.

34 INT. BOATHOUSE - DAY 34

One room over the water. Light comes up through the floorboards, moving, so the room seems slightly afloat. A stove red at the seams. A shelf of tins in no order at all, and among them a small radio, receiver only, its dial the same soft green as the one at the lower station.

On the cot: ANSEL, 50s, stubble gone most of the way to a beard. Eyes shut. His left leg is splinted with a broken oar handle, bound in net cord in neat, ugly knots.

TEO holds a mug of tea he has forgotten about. AUD feeds the stove and does not watch him. That is a kindness, and she knows it.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
Broken below the knee. Fever, on and off. I set it as well as I could, which was not very.

Teo kneels by the cot.

TEO
Ansel.

The eyes open and find him. A breath comes out with the shape of a word in it, and no word.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
He can't get it above a whisper. Don't make him.

Teo takes his hand. Ansel presses it. Once. Twice. Three times. Then lets go, spent.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER (CONT'D)
He did that to me the first night. I think it means he heard you.

Teo sets the tea down on the floor.

TEO
I called you. Every night at six, the whole line, and your name last, because you're the bottom one and you always answer last. I'd count thirty, because that's how long the relay takes when it's tired, and then thirty again in case it was more tired. Then I'd say goodnight to you anyway. I thought if I stopped saying it, that would be the night it was true.

And I wrote it down. Called the line, three answered. It's a good format, it's the one they taught us, and it hasn't got anywhere to put the one who didn't. I kept wanting to write you in the margin. I didn't, because it's a logbook. I should have written you in the margin.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
I heard you as well.

She points the poker at the shelf.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER (CONT'D)
That set listens. It doesn't talk. My husband bought it for the weather and was too mean to buy the other half. Nine nights: you, the two in the middle, then you saying goodnight to nothing. He lay there and heard every word.

TEO
Has it got a key? Even a click.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
It's got on and it's got off. We used to look at each other.

Teo takes the flat stone from his pack and holds it where Ansel can see, chalk arrow up. Ansel's eyes stay on it. Something in his face lets go.

TEO
His. It was on his doorstep. It means gone this way.

Aud looks at the boy who has carried a stone down a mountain for no reason a sensible person could give. He puts it in his coat pocket, where he can feel it.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
Drink your tea.

It has gone cold. He drinks all of it.

35 EXT. FIRE ROAD - DAY 35

First light under the trees. A green park truck comes down the gravel switchbacks in low gear. SOLLI, 30s, drives, a thermos wedged between the seats, like the road owes her nothing and she owes it less.

Before the bend: a quad bike nosed into the ditch. Pushed there, not crashed.

She gets out. The quad is cold. The jerrycan on the back rings, empty. Underneath, the fuel line has split along its seam, and a thin dark stripe runs back up the gravel the way the bike came.

RANGER
(into the handset)
Dispatch, Solli. I've got the quad, about the sixth bend down. Fuel line's split. No rider.
(beat)
He pushed it off the road. Most people leave them where they die.

She ties a strip of orange tape round the handlebar, so the next person will know someone has already been sorry about it.

36 INT. BASE - RADIO ROOM - DAY 36

Strip lights, one flickering in a rhythm nobody can fix. The big set, the weather board, a wall map with four red pins down the mountain. BASE STAFF (bg).

The DISPATCHER, 30s, at her desk, log open. IVERSEN stands behind her, which she has asked him twice not to do.

RANGER (V.O.)
...sixth from the top. Maybe seventh. Somebody's moved the marker posts.

DISPATCHER
Nobody's moved the marker posts.

RANGER (V.O.)
Then they've moved themselves.

She puts a yellow pin in the fire road, six bends down. She and Iversen look at the distance between it and the lowest red pin.

DISPATCHER
He's walking to the lake.

IVERSEN
There's nothing at the lake but a woman who hasn't spoken to anyone since her husband died.

DISPATCHER
Then she'll be glad of the company.
(into the phone)
Base dispatch. Search plane on standby for first light tomorrow, Kettle Lake side. I know about the weather. That's why I'm asking today.
(radio)
Solli. There's a man at the washout on the ridge road. Our inspector. Can you fetch him?

RANGER (V.O.)
Is he hurt?

DISPATCHER
He's counting things. Iversen says that's normal.

Iversen is already at the big set.

IVERSEN
Field Station, Iversen. Do you read?

The relay on the pass answers like gravel shaken in a tin. He keys again. He will keep keying.

37 INT. FIELD STATION - DAY 37

MARA at the radio, coat on indoors, Teo's log beside her and a pencil worn to a stub.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
...quad found... sixth bend... no rider...
(static)
...walking. Toward the lake.

The hiss takes him. She turns to a clean page and says it out loud, slowly, because somebody in this hut ought to.

MARA
Left at nine. Down by one. He'd look at everything twice, so call it noon before he left. The bike died near dark. Then he walked all night, because he's Teo.

She adds it up and underlines the answer, the way Delacroix underlined his 23.

MARA (CONT'D)
He's at the lake.
(beat)
Or he's somewhere between the sixth bend and the lake, and that's a bigger number.

She does not write that one down.

MARA (CONT'D)
(into the handset)
Iversen. Where's Delacroix?

IVERSEN (V.O.)
...fetching...

The hiss. She taps the pencil three times on the page, as if somebody might answer that.

38 EXT. RIDGE ROAD - DAY 38

DELACROIX sits on his pack at the washout, bivvy bag strapped. He has been here all night, and it shows only in the way he stands up when the truck comes round the bend below. SOLLI gets out.

RANGER
You're the inspector.

DELACROIX
I'm an inspector. Is the relief behind you?

RANGER
The relief is at base eating soup. The pass is shut. Solli, park service. They said you'd be counting things.

He considers being offended and decides it would take too long.

DELACROIX
Did you find the boy?

RANGER
I found his bike.

In the cab, the road falls away under his window. His lips move.

RANGER (CONT'D)
Go on. Out loud. I'd rather know.

DELACROIX
Thirty-seven.
(next bend)
Thirty-six. The map says forty.

RANGER
The map's right. There are two above the washout.

DELACROIX
I walked those. I was being told not to count.

RANGER
He pushed the bike off the road. In case someone needed to get past, I suppose.

DELACROIX
Three weeks on his own. Nine nights calling a man who didn't answer.

RANGER
And then he went to look.

DELACROIX
Somebody had to.

RANGER
You didn't.

She keeps her eyes on the road, which is the polite thing to do with a road like this.

DELACROIX
No.

RANGER
Twenty-nine.

DELACROIX
Twenty-eight. You missed one.

RANGER
Seeing if you'd notice.

He counts. She lets him, all the way down.

39 EXT. FIRE ROAD - DAY 39

From high on the ridge, the fire road is a pale thread laid down the mountain in loops. The truck is a green fleck on it, dragging a tail of dust that hangs in the still air.

At the sixth bend, the quad in the ditch. The orange tape on its handlebar lifts once in the truck's wake, and falls.

Far below, the lake: a grey coin, one thread of smoke going straight up from its far shore.

40 INT. FIELD STATION - LAB - DAY 40

A soldering iron heats on a gas ring, because the generator cannot be trusted with it today. The stripped spare transmitter lies open on the bench: a chassis and an opinion.

MARA saws its valve socket out, a square of old metal round it, and seats it in the punched lid of a tin that once held throat pastilles. Four flying leads. The valve fitted. It stands up out of the tin with wires hanging off it like the legs of something.

MARA
(to it)
Don't look at me like that.

On the bench supply, the valve warms to a dull orange. The needle lifts. She shakes the tin hard, the way a quad shakes on a fire road. The needle shivers. Stays.

It holds, on a bench at the top of the mountain, where it is no use to anybody. She looks at the clock, at the door, at the four hours of track between here and the set that needs it. She wraps the tin in a sock.

41 EXT. FIELD STATION - DAY 41

MARA packs on the step: the tin in its sock, inside a mug, inside a second sock. Tools. A five-litre can of fuel, which she lifts twice to be sure it is as heavy as the first time.

She writes on her knee:

MARA. LEFT 11.40. GONE TO THE LOWER STATION WITH A PART. RADIO ON, LISTENING ON OURS. IF THE GENERATOR STOPS, KICK THE HOUSING LOW ON THE LEFT. BACK BY SIX.

She crosses out BACK BY SIX. Writes it again underneath.

She wedges the note in the door frame and pins it with a flat stone from the yard. Inside, she turns the radio up, so anyone who comes will hear it.

Under its tarp, the generator coughs, and runs on. She goes down the track without looking back, because looking back at a generator has never once helped.

42 EXT. LOWER STATION - DAY 42

Hours later. MARA comes down the track with the fuel can in the other hand from the one she started with.

The door is still propped with a stone. She reads the ground first: quad tyres coming in, going out deeper on a full tank; one set of boots on the step, back and forth, a man walking about while he thinks. Beside the step, an empty jerrycan with its cap screwed back on. Teo screws caps back on.

On the doorstep, a clean pale square in the grit, where something flat lay for a long time. She puts her fingers on it.

MARA
You took it with you.

She leaves the door stone where it is. It is not hers to move.

43 INT. LOWER STATION - DAY 43

The cot made. The cold mug with its skin of tea, and beside it now Teo's, rinsed, upside down. The notebook: six o'clock, six o'clock, and on the last page an arrow and two initials.

MARA closes it the way you close a door on someone sleeping, and goes to work.

Out back, half her can into the cold generator, no more. Third pull, it catches. Inside, the dial brightens.

The back off the set, torch in her teeth. The output valve leans in its socket like a drunk against a wall. The socket is cracked through at one side. She keys.

MARA
Testing.

The needle jumps for one word and drops.

MARA (CONT'D)
One word and it cuts. There you are.

Out with the valve and the cracked socket. The pastille tin does not fit the gap. She makes it fit: wire, tape, a bent nail through the old screw hole. It looks like something a child made.

Leads soldered, valve in. She keys and holds the key down.

MARA (CONT'D)
One. Two. Three. Four. Five.

The needle stays up. A carrier, steady, for the first time in nine days, held in a pastille tin. She lets herself notice that, once.

MARA (CONT'D)
Base, this is the lower station. Do you read?

A breath of static. Then base answers, clean as a bell, as if someone were standing just behind her shoulder.

44 INT. BASE - RADIO ROOM - DAY 44

The big set speaks, clearly.

MARA (V.O.)
Base, lower station. Do you read?

A mug stops halfway to somebody's mouth. IVERSEN is at the set before the DISPATCHER has her headset on.

IVERSEN
Lower station, I read you.

MARA (V.O.)
Mara. The set here's been one word at a time for nine days.
(MORE)

MARA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
It's as many as I like now. Ansel walked out toward the lake. Teo went after him.

IVERSEN
Solli has Delacroix. They're going down. There's a plane for first light.

DISPATCHER
You're not coming through the relay.

MARA (V.O.)
He's low enough to see you from there. He never needed it. It was only ever the valve.

The room lets its breath out. Somebody laughs, short, and stops.

Iversen does not smile. He takes the dispatcher's pencil and writes the time in the log, small and neat: 14.52. Underlines it.

IVERSEN
Stay on the air, lower station. Six o'clock.

MARA (V.O.)
Six o'clock.

45 INT. BOATHOUSE - DAY 45

Afternoon light up through the floor. ANSEL sleeps, or near it. TEO darns a jumper with net twine, badly. AUD guts a fish without looking at it.

The receiver hisses, as it has for nine days. Then a voice comes out of it, small and clean, over the hiss instead of under it: Mara, calling base. Lower station, do you read.

Teo stands up so fast the crate goes over.

TEO
That's Mara. She fixes things.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
She's fixed his.

Teo snatches up the receiver.

TEO
Mara. It's Teo. We're at the lake, he's here, he's...

He stops. It has on and it has off.

And then he laughs: helpless, out loud, the first time in three weeks. It hurts a little and he does not stop. Aud looks at him as if he has done something she has waited a long time to see someone do in this room.

Teo sets the receiver by Ansel's hand. Ansel finds his wrist and presses it. Once. Twice. Three times.

TEO (CONT'D)
I know. I heard her too.

46 EXT. KETTLE LAKE - DAY 46

The shingle before the boathouse. The sky high and white and empty, which is what they want from it.

AUD drags a net off the line. TEO takes the other end without being asked.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
Straight. Pull it tight or it reads as a smudge.

A second net across the first: a cross, twenty paces each way, dark on pale stones. Then the white skiff, keel-up, set down at the crossing.

TEO
You've done this before.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
Eleven winters ago. My husband went out on the ice. Same nets. Same boat.

TEO
Did they come?

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
They came.

He waits for the rest. She lets him wait.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER (CONT'D)
That's what the cross is for. It isn't for what happens after.
(MORE)

BOATHOUSE KEEPER (CONT'D)
(beat)
This Delacroix. Is he coming?

TEO
He said he would.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
People say a lot of things.

TEO
He's not people. He's Delacroix.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
Then we'd better have something to feed him.

47 EXT. FIRE ROAD - DAY 47

The truck going down. DELACROIX watches the rocks at the road's edge. SOLLI watches the road.

Below the sixth bend, he puts a hand on the dashboard. She stops. He walks back and crouches by a rock. On its uphill face, where a walker would see it and a truck going down would not: a chalk arrow, pointing down.

RANGER
I drove past that this morning.

DELACROIX
It wasn't for you.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
(rubbing the chalk)
A week old. He didn't draw it. He followed it.
(beat)
One.

They drive on, slower. An arrow at every bend. Two. Three. Four. Seven. At the eighth it is not on the rock but on a tree, low down, at the height of a man on his knees.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
Eight.

RANGER
He was crawling by then.

DELACROIX
He was still drawing arrows.

Nine. Ten. Eleven. At the next bend the arrow points off the road, across the ditch, straight down through the trees.

RANGER
The road goes round by the dam. Another hour.

DELACROIX
He didn't go round. Twelve.

The road does not go to the lake. The arrows do.

48 EXT. FIRE ROAD - DUSK 48

The truck on the verge at the twelfth arrow, the light going amber. SOLLI takes a first aid pack, a handheld radio and a flare gun in a plastic case.

RANGER
You've got about half an hour of light.

DELACROIX
Thirty-five minutes.

She locks the truck. Then, after a look at the forest, unlocks it and leaves the keys under the seat.

RANGER (CONT'D)
In case someone needs to get past.

They go down through the trees, trunk to trunk, Solli easily, Delacroix carefully, which is not the same thing and takes longer. Pale scuffs of chalk at knee height, enough to say: still this way. He touches each one. His lips move.

The trees stop. The lake below in the last of the light, the boathouse across it, and on the shingle a dark cross with something white at its centre.

RANGER (CONT'D)
Somebody's expecting a plane.

DELACROIX
Somebody's expecting someone.

49 EXT. KETTLE LAKE - DUSK 49

DELACROIX and SOLLI come out onto the far shore. Across the bay a headlamp comes on, one small steady point.

It blinks. Off, on. Off, on.

DELACROIX
That's him.

RANGER
How do you know?

DELACROIX
He's counting.

Solli answers with her torch. Across the water, a figure goes to the white skiff and with one heave rights it.

RANGER (CONT'D)
There goes the signal.

The skiff comes across, AUD at the oars, rowing the way some people walk. She beaches it with one long stroke. TEO is out before it stops, wet to the knees again, with nothing rehearsed at all.

TEO
You came.

DELACROIX
We said we would.

Teo shakes his hand, and forgets to let go of it.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
Is he alive?

TEO
He's alive.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
Boat takes three. One of them's me.

RANGER
Take him first. He's older.

DELACROIX
I'm not older than you.

RANGER
You are, though.

Delacroix gets into the bow the way a man gets into cold water: all at once, because slowly would be worse. Aud pushes off.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
(barely audible)
Nine. Ten. Eleven.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
If you count my strokes, I'll take more of them.

DELACROIX
Twelve.

She takes the next stroke longer, deliberately. He counts it anyway.

50 INT. BOATHOUSE - NIGHT 50

Five people in one room over the water. Stove going hard, steam on the window, nowhere to stand that is not in someone's way.

SOLLI kneels by the cot, unwinding the splint one knot at a time. ANSEL watches her face, because that is where the news is.

RANGER
Who set this?

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
I did. It's an oar.

RANGER
It's a good oar.
(rewrapping it in Aud's knots)
He goes out by air. He won't stand the fire road.

She takes the handheld out onto the jetty.

RANGER (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Dispatch, Solli. Kettle Lake boathouse. Both found. One walking, one not...

DELACROIX sits by the cot. He and Ansel have met before; it is in both faces.

DELACROIX
I went up to the cairn. The first night.
(beat)
Twenty-five.

Something happens at the corner of Ansel's mouth, a long way from a smile but facing that way.

Delacroix holds out a hand to TEO without looking. Teo gives him the stone, warm from his pocket. Delacroix puts it in Ansel's hand and closes the fingers round it.

Ansel lifts his other hand. One finger raised. One stone short.

TEO
What does it mean?

DELACROIX
A cairn knocked down tells you there was weather. Rebuilt, it tells you there was a keeper. Rebuilt one stone short, it tells you the keeper wants somebody to come looking for the stone.

TEO
He knew someone would count it.

DELACROIX
He knew I would.

Ansel's eyes close, not from fever this time. From having been understood.

AUD at the stove does not pretend she was not listening.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
He can be understood after soup.

SOLLI comes back in with the cold on her.

RANGER
Plane's on for first light. If the weather lets it.

DELACROIX
It always lets it, until it doesn't.

On the shelf, the receiver hisses. Aud looks at the clock and turns it up.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
Six.

The room goes quiet without being asked.

51 INT. LOWER STATION - NIGHT 51

The generator rough but running. The pastille tin glowing faintly through its punched holes.

MARA sits where Ansel sat. At the top of the mountain, a note on a door says she is back by now.

MARA
Lower station calling the line.
Lower station calling the line.

She does not say goodnight first.

Faint, through the relay, the second station answers: a man saying his station's name and nothing else. Then the third: a woman, brisk, a kettle on behind her. Then the silence where the top station should be.

MARA (CONT'D)
Cold Spring. Keeper away. Mara, answering for it.
(beat)
Lower station. Keeper away. Mara, answering for it. On the air.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
Base. All stations heard. Solli called in from the boathouse. Both found. One walking, one not. Delacroix is with them. They're listening.

Mara puts the pencil down, parallel to the edge of the notebook, the way Teo would.

MARA
Goodnight, all stations. Goodnight, the boathouse. Goodnight, Teo.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
Goodnight, Mara.

The hiss comes back, softer, like something settling. She does not count anything. She lets the room do it.

52 INT. BASE - RADIO ROOM - DAWN 52

The base before the day staff. One lamp, the kettle on. IVERSEN at the big set with his coat on. He has not been home. The coat knows it.

The DISPATCHER has the log open and two pencils: one for good news, one for the other kind.

DISPATCHER
Search One, base. Radio check.

PILOT (V.O.)
Base, Search One. Loud and clear and a bit early. Off the water at six-oh-four, if anybody's keeping score.

Iversen is. He writes 0604 on the pad.

DISPATCHER
Kettle Lake, the boathouse on the north bay. One casualty. Look for a cross of nets on the shingle.

PILOT (V.O.)
Lovely spot. I'll bring a sandwich.

Iversen rubs out the time beside PASS on the weather board with his thumb and chalks a new one. Earlier.

DISPATCHER
Search One, the front is running early. The pass closes by mid-afternoon.

PILOT (V.O.)
Early I can work with. It's late that gets you.

IVERSEN
He's cheerful.

DISPATCHER
They pick them for it.

IVERSEN
Write down the time he said that.

It goes in the log, in the pencil for the other kind.

53 EXT. KETTLE LAKE - DAWN 53

Mist lies on the water so flat the lake looks paved. On the shingle, yesterday's cross of nets and the upturned skiff: white, the only clean edge in the world.

TEO at the end of the jetty, hands in his armpits. AUD, the boathouse keeper, with a mug she is not drinking from.

SOLLI, the ranger, crouched on the shingle, loading the truck's flare gun the way you load something you would rather not use twice.

TEO
How will he find it? In this.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
He won't. He'll find above it.

A drone, thin, coming and going as if the mist were tuning it. It moves left. Then right, which is worse.

RANGER
Then we'd better tell him.

She fires straight up. The flare climbs out of the mist into clear air nobody down here knew was there, and hangs, red, rocking on its little parachute.

TEO
He's seen it.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
He's seen something.

The PLANE comes down through the top of the mist: small, yellow, two floats, low enough that every board of the jetty hums.

Solli looks in the pouch.

RANGER
Two.

One night in a boathouse with Delacroix, and she has started doing it too.

54 EXT. KETTLE LAKE - DAY 54

The mist has burned off to rags. The PLANE taxis in to the jetty with a care that looks like good manners.

The PILOT, 40s, steps off the float in a jacket with too many pockets.

PILOT
Morning. Which of you's the casualty? Because you all look terrible.

RANGER
Inside. Leg below the knee, splinted. Fever since...

DELACROIX, on the boathouse step, coat buttoned to the throat.

DELACROIX
Ten days, today.

The pilot takes a notebook from one pocket, a pencil from another, a calculator from a third.

PILOT
It's only arithmetic, so nobody take it personally. I go light, or I go late, and I don't go late. Stretcher, him, and one more under eighty kilos. With boots.

RANGER
I've got a truck on the fire road.

PILOT
Then you're not going. Good. That's one.

Nobody looks at Teo, who is standing very straight, as if that would make him heavier.

TEO
I can walk back up. It's my station.

PILOT
Nobody's asking you to walk. I'm asking what you weigh.

DELACROIX
Sixty-one.

TEO
Sixty-four.

DELACROIX
Three weeks ago.

Teo opens his mouth and finds nothing in it.

PILOT
Twenty minutes. Then I go, with whoever's on the float.

He sits on the jetty and eats a sandwich from a fourth pocket, watching the weather like a film he has already seen.

55 INT. BOATHOUSE - DAY 55

Light off the water moves on the ceiling. ANSEL on the cot, splinted with an oar handle, eyes open, the cairn stone on his chest under one hand, the way you hold a ticket.

AUD packs him a bag without consulting anyone. DELACROIX by the door. TEO by the cot, where he has been all night.

DELACROIX
You go with him. You've listened to him not talk for nine days. Nobody else is qualified.

TEO
You don't leave a station.

DELACROIX
You left it.

That lands. Teo takes it.

TEO
Then let me go back now.

DELACROIX
Your station has a keeper.

TEO
Who?

DELACROIX
She fixes things.

TEO
She'll hate it.

DELACROIX
She'll do it properly and hate it. With her it's the same thing.

Ansel's free hand finds Teo's sleeve, and tugs. Once. Twice. Three times.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
(not looking up)
That's yes. He does three for yes.

TEO
What does he do for no?

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
He hasn't needed it.

Teo sits down on the edge of the cot. He has lost, and it does not look like losing.

56 EXT. BOATHOUSE - DAY 56

The boathouse door is off its hinges. Aud took it down with a screwdriver and no help, and nobody argued. ANSEL lies on it, tied down with net cord, the stone still under his hand.

SOLLI takes the head end, TEO the foot. The PILOT walks alongside, holding nothing.

PILOT
Mind the third board. The third board's a liar.

RANGER
You've been here before.

PILOT
I've been on a lot of jetties. They all have a third board.

Teo's arms shake. He does not say so. At the float, with quiet swearing from the pilot, Ansel goes in sideways, door and all.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
Bring it back.

PILOT
I'll bring it back.

AUD holds out a tin to Teo, its paint worn to the metal where thumbs have opened it for years.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER (CONT'D)
Open it on the flight.

She keeps hold of it a second longer than she needs to, and gives him the look she gave him over the oar, with the suspicion taken out and nothing put in its place.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER (CONT'D)
Don't drop it.

TEO
I won't.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
I didn't mean the tin.

She walks back up the jetty and steps over the third board without looking down.

57 EXT. KETTLE LAKE - DAY 57

The PLANE taxis out to the middle of the lake, where there is room to be wrong. Through the side window: TEO, in a seat facing backwards, the tin on his knees, one hand on the blankets over Ansel.

PILOT (V.O.)
(over the intercom)
All right back there?

TEO (V.O.)
Yes.

PILOT (V.O.)
That's a no. Hold on to him, not the seat.

Two white wakes open behind the floats like a zip. The floats lift, touch, lift and stay lifted.

On the jetty, AUD, arms folded. She does not wave. Then she does, once, the hand barely above the shoulder.

In the window, Teo has the tin open. Biscuits, in rows. On top, a square of paper, in pencil: 6 o'clock.

TEO (V.O.)
She waved.

PILOT (V.O.)
They usually do. Eventually.

58 INT. BASE - RADIO ROOM - DAY 58

Day staff in the background: one on the phone to the hospital, one making tea nobody will drink. IVERSEN at the set, his coat on the chair behind him.

PILOT (V.O.)
Base, Search One. Off the water at ten-fifty. Two aboard, one stretcher. And a door. I've promised to bring the door back.

DISPATCHER
(writing)
Two aboard, one stretcher. And a door.

Iversen moves his coat to the back of the chair, and sits down. The room notices. Nobody says so.

DISPATCHER (CONT'D)
You haven't sat down in four days.

IVERSEN
I've been busy.

DISPATCHER
You've been standing. It isn't the same.

IVERSEN
Read me the time again.

DISPATCHER
Ten-fifty.

It is written. He wanted to hear it said.

59 INT. LOWER STATION - DAY 59

Ansel's station, kept Ansel's way: cot made, mug upside down on the drainer. MARA at the set. Behind the grille the valve glows, steady, seated, hers.

Through the relay hiss, in pieces:

IVERSEN (V.O.)
...two aboard, one stretcher. Lower Station, copy?

MARA
Copy. Who's the second?

IVERSEN (V.O.)
The boy.

MARA
Good.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
The front's early. It shuts the pass tonight and sits, three days, maybe four. If you're going back up to the top station, go now. Otherwise you stay put.

MARA
How long on foot?

IVERSEN (V.O.)
Six hours. If the ridge is kind.

MARA
Is it ever?

IVERSEN (V.O.)
It was once. I was younger. Lower Station, I'm losing...

Hiss. She hangs the headphones where Ansel hangs them, the cord coiled three times.

MARA
Nobody up there, then.

She says it the way you say the name of a dog that has run off.

60 EXT. LOWER STATION - DAY 60

High above, the wind works along the ridge like someone looking for a way in.

MARA comes out with her pack on. Teo's jerrycan stands by the lean-to. She tips it with her boot: a third left. He stopped short of the last of it, the way you leave the last biscuit. She straps it to the pack, which complains.

She shuts the station door. Opens it again. No stone on the step: Ansel's went down the valley with Teo.

She picks one from the yard, flat and grey, the kind Delacroix would approve of without saying so, and props the door with it, open a hand's width.

No chalk. No arrow. The stone says the other thing a keeper's stone can say: someone has been here.

She goes up the track and does not look back.

61 EXT. RIDGE ROAD - DAY 61

The truck comes up the switchbacks faster than the gravel likes, under a sky the colour of a bruise on its second day.

In the cab: SOLLI driving, DELACROIX with the map on his knee, unread.

RANGER
How many?

DELACROIX
Twenty-two. To the washout. I count down on the way up. It's quicker.

RANGER
It isn't.

DELACROIX
It feels quicker.

RANGER
Your engineer. Will she have gone back up?

DELACROIX
She doesn't like being told to stay put.

RANGER
Nobody does.

DELACROIX
Nobody does it as much as she doesn't.

The rain arrives the way it does up here: all at once, and from the side.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
Three. Two.

RANGER
I can see it, Delacroix.

The washout. She stops where the road stops.

DELACROIX
Two hours to the top. Less, if we don't talk.

RANGER
Then don't.

Solli pockets the flare gun, two left, and takes the rope. They go round the washout on the rock, Delacroix first because he has done it.

The truck sits where it was left, wipers stopped halfway, like somebody interrupted mid-sentence.

62 EXT. RIDGE - DUSK 62

The storm comes up the valley like a wall pushed by somebody who means it.

MARA comes up the last of the track bent under the pack and the can. Six hours. The ridge was not kind.

She stops at the cairn because her legs decide for her. She has never counted anything she did not have to. She counts now, touching each stone.

MARA
Twenty-three. Twenty-four.

A gust hits her. She holds on to the cairn, and it holds.

MARA (CONT'D)
Twenty-five.

She has no idea whether that is the right number. She has a feeling Delacroix would. Any stone at her feet would do. It is not her cairn, and it is not her count.

Above her the mast has started to sing, and it is not one note, and it is not two. The wind is from the east. They don't get an east wind. They got one once.

63 INT. FIELD STATION - DUSK 63

The hut has gone cold in the way of a room nobody expected back. The tarp on the north wall strains at its lashings. Outside, the generator coughs on and off, like an argument.

MARA takes the can straight back out. Through the window, her torch at the generator. The coughing stops. Starts. Steadies, nearly.

She comes back in wet to the shoulder and sits at the radio.

MARA
Field Station to Base.

Hiss. The relay, or the antenna, or the weather, or all three, which is how it usually goes.

She holds the handset, thumb off the key, and talks to it anyway, as if Teo were on the other end and asleep.

MARA (CONT'D)
You'd have asked me why I took the job. He did. People think it's the quiet.
(MORE)

MARA (CONT'D)
My father fixed things in a town, for people who stood behind him and told him it had been fine yesterday. He'd find the bolt with no thread, and they'd say it had always been like that, and it had. Nobody down there tells you what's broken. They'd rather you didn't look.

Up here nothing pretends. The wind shows you the gap. The generator tells you it's dying, out loud, every night. You told the radio every night that the fourth station didn't answer, and nobody wrote it down. I'm writing it down. That's why. Somebody has to say it's broken, and fix it, and not need thanking. I don't need thanking. I'd just like somebody, once, to have noticed.

Her thumb has not been on the key the whole time. She keys it.

MARA (CONT'D)
Field Station. Still here.

The hiss comes back, ordinary, and she finds that will do.

64 EXT. FIELD STATION - NIGHT 64

The storm is unpacking. The guy wires shriek in four keys. The fuel drum walks across the yard on its own.

DELACROIX comes up the last of the slope with SOLLI behind him on a rope. They are ten yards off when the hut door opens. MARA stands in it, the light behind her.

MARA
You came.

DELACROIX
You had the door open before we knocked.

MARA
Teo does that.

DELACROIX
He said it's different, seeing it.

MARA
It is.

RANGER
Solli. Park service. I'd shake your hand, but I can't find mine.

MARA
Mara. Come in, it's warmer.

All three of them know the rest of it.

MARA (CONT'D)
It isn't. But it's out of the wind.

Delacroix stops on the step and looks at the generator. Running. Not well. Running.

DELACROIX
You fuelled it.

MARA
A third of a can. Teo left it. It'll go till morning.

DELACROIX
And then?

MARA
Then it's morning.

The wind slams the door behind them, the way it did behind Teo.

65 INT. FIELD STATION - NIGHT 65

Three people round a table built for one. SOLLI has the chair, because she is the guest. DELACROIX has an upturned crate, which is beneath him, which he knows.

The tarp on the north wall goes for the third time since Teo left, all three lashings at once, and the storm is in the room. The stove flame lies down. The tins walk.

DELACROIX
Board.

MARA
Bunkhouse.

She is out of the door, Solli after her. Delacroix puts his back to the gap. It is about the size of him, which is the first time that has been useful.

They come back with a bunk board and put it over the gap. It fits, nearly, which up here is the same as fits.

MARA (CONT'D)
Nails.

Delacroix finds them in her coat pocket and puts them in her hand one at a time.

DELACROIX
Six. Seven. Eight.

MARA
Eight's enough.

She drives them with the back of a spanner. The storm leans on the board and the board leans back.

RANGER
You took the one with no names on it.

MARA
Nobody's name should face the weather.

The room is a room again, smaller than before. Delacroix spoons beans into three mugs, the same number of spoons each.

RANGER
Did he go easily? The boy.

DELACROIX
He went sideways. With a door.

RANGER
Is it always like this up here?

MARA
No.

DELACROIX
Usually there's only one of us.

66 INT. BASE - RADIO ROOM - NIGHT 66

Rain on the window. Background: one of the day staff asleep across two chairs.

IVERSEN at the set. The relay light, which has flickered for four days, goes steady. Then out. Switch, wait, switch. Nothing.

IVERSEN
That's it. For good. Log it.

The DISPATCHER writes the time, then turns back through the pages and reads, in the voice people keep for names.

DISPATCHER
"Eighteen hundred. Top station calling the line. Fourth station, no answer." Nine nights of that. "Eighteen hundred. Lower station calling. All stations answered." "Ten-fifty. Two aboard, one stretcher. And a door." "Nineteen-twelve. Relay failed."

IVERSEN
Write the top station. Unknown.

DISPATCHER
That isn't a log entry.

IVERSEN
It is tonight.

It goes in. The pencil, Iversen notices, is the one for good news.

67 EXT. RADIO MAST - NIGHT 67

The antenna has been torn off true and swings on one bracket, banging the steel like somebody asking to be let in.

MARA in a harness, a torch taped to her shoulder. DELACROIX braced against the fuel drum, the safety line through his gloves. She clips on and climbs.

DELACROIX
One. Two. Three.

She climbs. He counts. The wind no longer pulls at her like it wants her for something. It has decided.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
Eleven. Twelve.

A gust leans the mast. She stops, cheek to the steel. He stops counting.

MARA
Don't stop.

DELACROIX
Thirteen.

The line goes taut in his hands and stays taut.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
Thirty-one. Thirty-two.

She gets an arm round the antenna and holds it true with her whole body.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
Forty-four.

MARA
I know. I'm here.

One turn. The wind takes it out of true. She drags it back. Two turns. Three. The mast's shriek drops to something that sounds as if it has noticed.

DELACROIX
Is that it?

MARA
That's it.

He counts her down, all forty-four, backwards, and she lets him say every one.

68 INT. FIELD STATION - LATER 68

MARA at the set, still in the harness, dripping. DELACROIX behind her. SOLLI on the cot in a blanket.

MARA
Base, Field Station.

A click, and a voice, patient, a long way off, but clean.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
Field Station, Iversen. I hear you.
There's no relay. You're coming
straight over the ridge.

DELACROIX
(leaning in)
Three here. Mara, the ranger, me.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
Three. I'm writing it down.

They can hear the pencil.

RANGER
Tell him the truck's at the washout. Nobody tows it.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
I heard. Nobody tows it. Field Station, they landed. He's with the doctors. The boy is sitting outside on a chair with a tin on his knee and won't give it to anybody.

Mara lets go of the key. A moment.

MARA
Copy.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
Six o'clock tomorrow. You call the line.

Delacroix puts his hand on her wet shoulder, briefly. Neither of them mentions it.

69 INT. FIELD STATION - BUNKHOUSE - NIGHT 69

Four bunks, three boards. SOLLI on a lower bunk in all her clothes, her torch on the names carved by years of relief teams. ANSEL, three times, years apart. The photograph: four keepers at a summer handover, all smiling, none of them now.

She takes out a penknife. Opens it. Closes it. She has not earned a place on that wall.

Torch off. The mast has found its one long note again, as if the east wind had never happened.

RANGER
Goodnight.

To the photograph, or the names, or the mast. She lies awake listening to it.

70 EXT. FIELD STATION - NIGHT 70

A lull. Over the station the storm has stopped to draw breath.

DELACROIX in the yard, no torch. The fuel drum has walked a yard toward the edge. He puts his shoulder to it and walks it back.

The generator runs. Even. Not a cough in it. He listens the way you listen to somebody breathing in the next room.

His hand goes to his watch, out of a habit older than the station, and stops.

DELACROIX
No.

He pulls his sleeve down over it and goes back in.

71 INT. FIELD STATION - NIGHT 71

The board over the gap creaks like a ship. MARA on the cot, boots off for the first time in four days. DELACROIX in the chair, the handset on the table, not in his fist.

MARA
I saw a light. The first night, from the mast. Low on the far slope, where the map has nothing. Then it went out.

DELACROIX
I know. You didn't come down for a minute and a half. You're never a minute and a half.

MARA
If I'd said, we'd have gone that night.

DELACROIX
In the dark, down a slope we didn't know, with one torch.

MARA
He was signalling.

DELACROIX
Aud says he came in with a lamp and no oil in it. He used it all up on us.

MARA
And I didn't say.

DELACROIX
Somebody saw it. Up here, that counts.

MARA
You should sleep.

DELACROIX
You should stop saying that.

She almost laughs, and turns to the wall. He turns the radio down. Not off.

72 EXT. FIELD STATION - DAWN 72

The storm has gone in the night the way it came, all at once, without explaining itself. Everything glitters: frost on the guy wires, ice on the generator tarp.

MARA comes out with a mug in each hand and looks at the sky, which is blue from one ridge to the other. She does not trust it.

DELACROIX is at the edge of the yard, looking down the valley. SOLLI comes out of the bunkhouse with her boots in one hand.

RANGER
Is it always like this after? Like it's sorry.

DELACROIX
It isn't sorry. It's resting.

Mara holds out the second mug. Delacroix turns for it. Solli takes it. Delacroix turns back to the valley as if that was what he meant to do.

Through the open door the radio wakes. Voices: a man out of breath, a woman laughing at him, somebody reading out a position and being corrected.

MARA
They're through the pass.

DELACROIX
Four.

RANGER
I'll get the truck down before they want the road.

DELACROIX
Thank you. For the switchbacks.

RANGER
You'd have counted them anyway.

DELACROIX
Yes. But you let me.

She hands Mara the empty mug and starts down toward the washout. She does not look back. People who drive for a living rarely do.

73 INT. BASE - RADIO ROOM - DAY 73

Daylight through the long window, for the first time in four days. Somebody has wiped CLOSED off the weather board and written OPEN.

IVERSEN sits at the big set with his coat still on. Base staff (bg) move slowly, the way people move after something heavy has been put down.

The telephone on the wall rings. Nobody uses the telephone. The DISPATCHER answers it, listens, writes, and covers the mouthpiece.

DISPATCHER
The hospital. He keeps the leg. They say he complained the whole time, in a whisper.

IVERSEN
He would.

He holds out his hand for the phone. He holds it to his ear and opens his mouth, and the hospital waits, politely, a long way off.

He hands it back.

IVERSEN (CONT'D)
Tell them thank you.

She does, and hangs up, and writes in the log.

IVERSEN (CONT'D)
What did you write?

DISPATCHER
Ten forty. Hospital. Ansel keeps the leg.

IVERSEN
Underline it.

She underlines it. Then, because he is still watching, she underlines it again.

Iversen takes his coat off.

74 EXT. RIDGE ROAD - DAY 74

From high above, the ridge road: grey switchbacks laid down the mountain like a dropped rope. One small truck on it, going down. No dust today. The storm has laid all of it.

At the washout an arm comes out of the driver's window, one hand raised, to nobody. Up on the ridge, nobody is looking.

IN THE CAB

SOLLI drives with one wrist over the wheel and picks up the handset.

RANGER
Dispatch, Solli. Road's open to the washout. After that it's legs.

She takes the next bend, and the next. Her lips move. She catches herself at nine and stops, annoyed.

RANGER (CONT'D)
That's his job.

She takes the tenth without counting it, which costs her something.

75 EXT. FIRE ROAD - DAY 75

The quad lies where Teo pushed it, nose down in the heather, a cobweb strung from the handlebar to the mirror.

SOLLI crouches at the fuel line, at the leak she found three days ago, and wraps tape round it, which will make no difference to anything.

RANGER
You did fine. You got him most of the way.

She chains it to the truck and pulls away. The quad follows, rattling over every stone like a drawer of cutlery going down a staircase.

At the bend, a chalk arrow on a rock, half washed off by the storm. Still pointing. Solli slows beside it for as long as it takes the quad to stop rattling. Then she drives on.

76 EXT. KETTLE LAKE - DAY 76

The lake is flat and pale and very still, as if it has been told to behave.

On the shingle the nets still lie in their cross around the upturned white skiff. AUD takes it apart the way she laid it: one net at a time, shaken out, folded, laid over her arm.

Behind her, through the open boathouse door, the old receiver is on. It is not six o'clock. Base is calling the line in daylight, which it never does: a count after the storm.

She stops folding.

One by one the stations answer. She knows every voice. The second. The third. A pause. Then the lower station, a voice she does not know, careful, reading off a card.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
Took your time.

Then the top station: Mara, one word, and done.

Aud has listened to all of it. She always does. She turns the skiff right way up and drags it to the water. The shingle is only shingle.

77 INT. BOATHOUSE - DAY 77

The cot where Ansel lay is stripped, the blanket folded square at its foot. An oar by the door is missing its handle.

The PILOT comes in without waiting to be asked, a crate on one shoulder and a box under his arm.

PILOT
Groceries. Paraffin. Tea, the good kind. I was told to say the good kind.

He hands AUD a folded list. She reads it. It is in order of size.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
How is he?

PILOT
Tidy.

He opens the box: a radio, newer than anything in the room.

PILOT (CONT'D)
Base sent it. It talks back.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
I don't want it.

PILOT
They said you'd say that.

He wires it up anyway, the aerial out of the window to the gutter, while she watches and does not help.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
I've listened to a radio for thirty years.

PILOT
This one listens back. It's the park's. Yours to look after.

She thinks about that, as if it might be a trick. Then she puts the new radio on the shelf and moves the old receiver one inch to the left to make room. It is the most she will concede, and they both know it.

She takes down two cups, puts one back, and takes it down again.

78 EXT. BOATHOUSE - DAY 78

Afternoon. The PILOT refuels the plane on the jetty.

AUD sits on the step with the new handset in her lap, the lead running through the window like a leash. She checks her watch. A little after three. It is not six, and it is not tomorrow.

She keys it anyway.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
This is the lake. The boathouse. On the lake.

A voice comes back at once, clear as water from a tap: base, pleased, asking her to say again...

She switches it off.

PILOT
You start tomorrow. Six o'clock.

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
I was practising.

PILOT
How did it go?

BOATHOUSE KEEPER
They answer very fast.

She does not put the handset down. She sits with it a while longer, in case.

79 EXT. KETTLE LAKE - DUSK 79

Out by the reed point, where Ansel came down to the water, a SECOND BOAT CREW (bg) lower an orange marker buoy from a rowboat, then sit and look at it, because there is nothing else to do with a buoy.

The plane taxis out from the jetty.

IN THE COCKPIT

PILOT
Base, Kettle Lake, outbound. One aboard. Me and an empty seat.
(listens; smiles)
And your boathouse is on the air. She hung up on you. I'd take that as a yes.

BACK TO SCENE

The plane lifts and banks low over the buoy, waggles its wings once, which is not regulation, and climbs away toward the pass.

The buoy goes on bobbing where somebody got as far as the water.

80 EXT. LOWER STATION - DAY 80

The door stands propped with a flat stone, the way Mara left it. DELACROIX sits beside it on the step. He has counted the slates on the lean-to roof. Twenty, two cracked.

The RELIEF TEAM (bg) come down the track, four of them, heavy packs, talking. They stop talking when they see him.

Among them, the NEW KEEPER (bg): a broad, quiet man with a beard he has clearly grown for the job. Delacroix shakes his hand, once, properly.

DELACROIX
You're the lower station. The door stays as it is until you've read the notebook. It means someone has been here. Someone who meant to come back.
(counts them with his eyes)
(MORE)

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
Two of you stay. Two come up with me.

He turns back to the new keeper.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
The transmitter has a carrier made out of a tin. Don't touch the tin. Six o'clock, every night. If you can't answer, light the lamp on the slope. Somebody up top will see it.
(beat)
Eventually.

The new keeper nods. Delacroix goes inside.

81 INT. LOWER STATION - DAY 81

The room as neat as the first night. The radio dial glows green, steady now. Inside the open panel, the tin carrier, with a strip of Mara's tape across it that says DON'T.

DELACROIX opens Ansel's notebook. Six o'clock. Six o'clock. The hand getting smaller down the page, as if the man writing it were going a long way off, which he was.

He counts the entries with one finger.

DELACROIX
Nine.

He takes out his pencil, worn to a stub. Below the last entry, small and neat, he writes the date, and one word.

INSERT: THE NOTEBOOK

The date, and "answered".

BACK TO SCENE

He does not underline it. It does not need it.

He leaves the notebook open beside the radio and goes out to tell them they can close the door.

82 EXT. RIDGE - DAY 82

The cairn in clear daylight. Down the valley, smoke from the lower station's pipe, for the first time since Ansel left it.

DELACROIX comes up the spur onto the ridge. MARA is already at the cairn with a stone in both hands: flat, grey, a rusty ring on one face.

DELACROIX
That's from the yard.

MARA
It held the generator tarp down for three weeks. It's done its time.

DELACROIX
The other one went with him. Solli says he wouldn't let go of it for the X-ray.

MARA
Then it's his.

She sets the new stone on top. It rocks. She turns it a quarter turn and chinks a sliver of rock under one edge, carefully, as if somebody is going to check.

Somebody is going to check.

Delacroix takes his gloves off and touches each stone with a bare finger, top to bottom, the way he did in the dark. His lips move.

He starts again at the top. Slower. Every stone.

He puts his gloves back on and says nothing. From Delacroix this is a speech, and Mara has worked with him long enough to hear all of it.

MARA (CONT'D)
Good.

They stand a while, sighted down the valley like the cairn, toward the smoke.

83 EXT. FIELD STATION - DAY 83

Two of the RELIEF TEAM (bg) come up the last of the slope, the NEW TOP KEEPER (bg) between them: early twenties, a new coat, a pack too big for her and very well packed. She has the look of someone who has rehearsed what to say and forgotten all of it.

MARA waits in the doorway until they arrive.

MARA
You came.

The new keeper opens her mouth. Nothing comes.

MARA (CONT'D)
That's all right. Nobody remembers it.

DELACROIX looks at her boots and nods. That is a welcome, and she seems to know it.

At the generator Mara lifts the tarp. Six new bolts. She taps each one.

MARA (CONT'D)
Every one has a thread. If one ever turns in your fingers and keeps turning, it's lying to you. Take it out.

The stone that held the tarp is gone. The new keeper looks round the yard for another, as if she is meant to do it now. Delacroix approves of this privately.

The mast takes the wind and gives back one long low note. The new keeper looks up.

MARA (CONT'D)
It sings in a north wind. One note. In a west wind it's two, and they don't agree.

DELACROIX
And an east wind?

MARA
We got one once.

She goes in first, the way the keeper does.

84 INT. FIELD STATION - DAY 84

The map is back above the radio, creased across the middle from the night it came down. Four pins.

MARA touches the lowest pin. It is only a pin. She moves nothing.

Beside the map, DELACROIX looks at what he wrote the first night: 23, underlined. He licks his thumb and rubs. It smears into a grey cloud with a line under it.

MARA
You could leave it.

DELACROIX
It was wrong.

MARA
It wasn't wrong. It just wasn't enough.

He takes a rubber from his pocket and works at it properly. The underline goes last.

MARA (CONT'D)
How many was it? In the end.

DELACROIX
I stopped counting.

She looks at him.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
Ninety-one. I stopped writing them down.

What is left is a pale patch, cleaner than the wall around it. You would only see it if you knew.

85 INT. FIELD STATION - LAB - DAY 85

The bench, cleared, the spare parts sorted into tins. MARA squares Teo's logbooks with the flat of her hand.

She opens the top one at the last page. Twenty-one days of perfect entries. Nine of "Called the line. 3 answered." Then her own hand, in his format.

She writes the date and, in his format:

INSERT: THE LOGBOOK

"Called the line. 4 answered."

BACK TO SCENE

Her pencil hovers. There is room on the line for something more. She does not write it.

MARA
There.

She hears herself say it to an empty room, and does not take it back. She puts the pencil in the spine, where Teo kept it, and turns off the lamp.

86 INT. BASE - RADIO ROOM - DAY 86

The door lets in a slice of cold and TEO, on his own two feet, in a hospital jumper a size too large, hair combed flat with water. He looks as if he has been folded and put away carefully and then taken out again.

The DISPATCHER takes off her headset.

DISPATCHER
Teo.

He has never heard his name in this room except through a radio.

IVERSEN stands. He is older than his voice. Teo shakes his hand, then the dispatcher's, then Iversen's again.

TEO
Sorry. It's different. Seeing it.

IVERSEN
It is.

He turns the log round so Teo can read it: nine nights, each logged late, each with Teo's name.

IVERSEN (CONT'D)
Nine nights. Nobody passed it on. I'm sorry. I should have answered you.

Teo has rehearsed nothing for this.

TEO
You're answering now.

Iversen almost smiles. He turns his own chair at the big set toward Teo.

IVERSEN
Sit there. It's warmer.
(beat)
It isn't. But it's out of the draught.

Teo sits.

87 EXT. RIDGE ROAD - DAY 87

MARA and DELACROIX come down from the hut, packs on, the wind behind them for once.

At the first bend below the yard, under the grass, Delacroix stops.

DELACROIX
Forty.

MARA
You started at thirty-eight last time.

DELACROIX
I was two out. The grass has two. You can't see them coming up.

The next, only a shelf of rock under the turf.

DELACROIX (CONT'D)
Thirty-nine.

The washout. They go round on the rock, Mara first. The gravel holds this time.

MARA
Thirty-eight.

DELACROIX
Thirty-eight.

SERIES OF SHOTS

A) Thirty, twenty-nine. Two voices, out of step.

B) Twenty. In step now, the cloud lifting off the ridge behind them like a lid somebody finally remembered.

C) Nine. Mara says it a beat before he does.

BACK TO SCENE

The last bend, where the grass gives up and lets the gravel have it. They take it together.

MARA
One.

He unfolds the paper map and looks at it for the first time in five days.

DELACROIX
Forty. The map was right.

MARA
You sound disappointed.

DELACROIX
I'd got used to it lying.

He folds it to the same square, puts it away, and follows her a pace behind, the way he walked up.

88 EXT. FIRE ROAD - DUSK 88

The fire road along the far shoulder of the hill, gravel pink in the last light. Far below, Kettle Lake: a grey coin going dark.

MARA and DELACROIX walk it side by side. At the bend where the chalk arrow was, the rock is clean.

Down at the end of the boathouse jetty, a light comes on. One small steady point. It does not flicker.

MARA
There's a light.

She says it at once, this time.

DELACROIX
I see it.

MARA
It's steady.

DELACROIX
She means it to be.

Delacroix does not count anything. He keeps his hands in his pockets and looks at the light.

They walk on, and the light stays on the water behind them, getting smaller, and does not go out.

89 INT. BASE - RADIO ROOM - NIGHT 89

One minute to six. The DISPATCHER has the log open at a clean page. TEO sits at the big set with the handset in both hands. IVERSEN stands behind him, having decided not to help.

TEO
Base to the line. Six o'clock.

The top station: a young woman, a little too fast. Tick. The second, an old voice, bored, the best sound in the world. Tick. The third. Tick. A gap. Then the lower station, careful, reading off a card. Tick.

TEO (CONT'D)
That's four.

He reaches for the key. Iversen's hand on his shoulder. Wait. Ten seconds of hiss.

Then a woman's voice, gruff, no call sign, says one word: "Boathouse." The line clicks dead.

The room laughs. Teo laughs loudest.

IVERSEN
She answered. Write it down.

DISPATCHER
Who's calling?

IVERSEN
Everybody.

DISPATCHER
And who isn't?

IVERSEN
Nobody.

She writes it, and underlines it, and does not need to be asked.

TEO
Goodnight.

Down the line, one by one, small and far off, they say it back. Even, after a while, the lake.

90 EXT. FIELD STATION - NIGHT 90

The yard at night. Clear, cold, stars down to the ridge on every side.

The generator runs under its tarp, even and ordinary, a new stone on the corner, a little small for the job. Above it the mast takes a north wind and gives back one long low note.

In the hut window the radio light glows. Behind it the NEW TOP KEEPER (bg) writes in a logbook, carefully, in a hand that will get smaller down the page as the weeks go on and then, one day, bigger again.

On the ridge the cairn stands sighted down the valley. Twenty-six stones. Nobody counting them tonight.

Down the valley the lower station shows one lamp. Further off, at the edge of the lake, another. Everything that is lit is lit on purpose.

The mast holds its note.

FADE OUT.

THE END